| SAKSHI MALIK | 31 | BAJRANG PUNIA | 29 | VINESH PHOGAT | 29 | Wrestlers |





Photographs by PTI

FIGHT OF THEIR LIVES

NO SACRIFICE WAS TOO BIG FOR THE THREE STAR WRESTLERS, WHO LED AN ICONIC PROTEST AGAINST AN ALLEGED PREDATOR AND AN UNRESPONSIVE ESTABLISHMENT

By Suhani Singh

WHILE EXPENDING BEADS OF SWEAT ON THE MAT FOR INDIA, THEY WERE INDIA'S FINEST. But outmanoeuvring a *bahubali* MP of the ruling party, who faces multiple charges of sexual harassment, was a bout rather more daunting and infinitely more exhausting than performing tackles on wrestling opponents.

To their endless credit, their spine never gave way. On December 21, Sakshi Malik—India's only woman Olympic medallist in wrestling—let a final call for justice ring out as she hung up her boots, tears flowing, at a presser in New Delhi. Seated beside her were her equally distraught peers and comrades-in-arms,